KATSU DOJO · GAINESVILLE, FL · SHODAN (1st DAN) PREP

Daniel's Shito-ryu Black Belt Study Guide

Kihon, kata, bunkai, kumite, kobudo, history and the questions you're most likely to be asked — with flashcards, a quiz and a 6-week plan that remembers your progress on this device.

Read this first — requirements vary. We do **not** have Katsu Dojo's official shodan test sheet. Shito-ryu has several branches (Shito-kai/WSKF, Seito, Hayashi-ha, Tani-ha/Shukokai and others) and each federation and dojo sets its own syllabus. Everything here is a **typical** picture assembled from published Shito-ryu federation material (see Sources). **Kata lists are "typical," not definitive.** Confirm the exact kata, kihon combinations, kumite format, kobudo expectations and any oral/written portion with Sensei.

Dojo notes: Katsu Dojo teaches traditional Shito-ryu plus Okinawan kobudo (bo, tonfa, sai, kama, nunchaku, tanbo). Daniel's schedule: **sparring on Tuesdays**, **weapons after Wednesday class**. Progress (checkboxes, best quiz score) is saved only in this browser (localStorage).

1 · How a typical shodan test runs

Formats differ, but most Shito-ryu dan gradings follow this flow. Published syllabi (e.g., Shitoryu Karate Canada, which is WSKF/JKF-Shitokai affiliated, and Karate Canada's Shito-ryu dan guideline) list kihon, kata, bunkai, kumite and knowledge (history/terminology) as the core components.

Typical order

1. **Rei & line-up**: bow in, kneel (*seiza*), *mokuso*, bow to *shomen*/sensei/panel.
2. **Kihon**: stationary basics, then *ido kihon* (moving) and *renzoku* (combinations) up and down the floor, on count and without.
3. **Kata**: usually one or two required (*shitei*) kata plus one of your choice (*tokui*) and/or one picked by the examiner. Panels often call a random Pinan.
4. **Bunkai**: applications of a required kata (often Bassai Dai) and your tokui kata with a partner.
5. **Kumite**: prearranged (ippon/sanbon, sometimes Pinan *hokei kumite*) then *jiyu kumite* (free sparring), sometimes several rounds or partners.
6. **Knowledge**: oral questions (history, terminology, principles); some federations add a short written essay.
7. **Closing**: bow out; results may come the same day or later.

What examiners look for

- **Stances**: correct depth, width, weight distribution; stable transitions.
- **Technique**: correct path, chamber and *hikite*, target level.
- **Kime**: focused power at impact, then relax.
- **Hips & timing**: body moves as one; hand and foot finish together.
- **Kata accuracy**: sequence, *embusen* (start = finish point), rhythm, speed contrast, breathing.
- **Eyes & spirit**: *chakugan* (look before turning), *kiai*, *zanshin*.
- **Understanding**: bunkai that works at realistic distance.
- **Kumite**: distance (*maai*), timing, control, sportsmanship.
- **Attitude**: etiquette, effort when tired, humility.

WKF kata judging uses a similar split: technical performance (stances, techniques, transitions, timing, breathing, kime, conformance to style) and athletic performance (strength, speed, balance).

Example published standards (reference only): Shitoryu Karate Canada lists shodan kata as mandatory **Bassai Dai** and **Seienchin** plus a tokui kata from Pinan 1–5, Juroku, Jitte, Itosu Rohai Shodan, Naihanchin Shodan, Matsumura Rohai or Shinsei; Bassai Dai bunkai; Pinan hokei kumite; point sparring. Karate Canada's Shito-ryu guideline also lists Seienchin and Bassai for shodan, plus bunkai and jiyu kumite. Other groups (e.g., Shito-ryu Genbu-kai) let the examiner pick from ~15 kata including Jion, Wanshu, Wankan and Kushanku (Kosokun) Dai. Jion and Matsukaze are nidan-level requirements in some syllabi.

2 · Kihon (basics)

Names follow common Shito-ryu usage; dojos differ. Shito-ryu often calls the outward middle block *yoko uke* or *soto uke* and the inward one *uchi uke* / *yoko uchi uke*. Use Sensei's names.

Tachikata (stances)

Name	Meaning	One-line cue
Heisoku dachi	closed-foot stance	Feet together, knees soft, tall spine.
Musubi dachi	V stance	Heels together, toes ~45° apart; used for rei.
Hachiji dachi	natural stance	Feet shoulder-width, toes slightly out; the yoi position.
Heiko dachi	parallel stance	Feet shoulder-width and parallel.
Zenkutsu dachi	front stance	Long and low, front knee over toes, back leg firm.
Moto dachi	short front stance	Shorter than zenkutsu; Shito-ryu's mobile fighting base.
Shiko dachi	square (sumo) stance	Toes out ~45°, knees pushed out over toes, hips low, back straight.
Neko ashi dachi	cat stance	Most weight on back leg, front heel up, front foot ready to kick.
Kokutsu dachi	back stance	Weight mostly back, back knee bent outward, front leg light.
Sanchin dachi	hourglass stance	Short stance, knees in, pelvis tucked, grip the floor (Naha-te root).
Naihanchi dachi	straddle stance	Wide, feet parallel or slightly in, knees pressed out; moves sideways.
Kosa dachi	crossed-leg stance	Legs crossed, weight on front leg, back knee tucked behind front knee.
Sagi ashi dachi	heron (one-leg) stance	Stand on one leg, raised foot by the knee, stay balanced.

Tsuki & uchi (punches and strikes)

Name	Meaning	One-line cue
Choku-zuki (seiken)	straight punch	Twist at the last moment; first two knuckles, wrist straight.
Oi-zuki (jun-zuki)	lunge/stepping punch	Step and punch land together; same-side hand and foot.
Gyaku-zuki	reverse punch	Drive from the back leg, snap the hip, pull hikite hard.
Maete-zuki / kizami-zuki	lead-hand jab	Fast and short, shoulder relaxed, recover instantly.
Nihon-zuki	double punch	Jodan then chudan with no pause.
Age-zuki	rising punch	Short upward arc to the chin.
Morote-zuki	two-hand punch	Both fists together from a stable stance.
Tate-zuki	vertical-fist punch	Fist vertical; short range.
Ura-zuki	close punch	Palm-up punch at close range.
Nukite	spear hand	Fingers tight, slightly bent.
Shuto uchi	knife-hand strike	Edge of the hand; thumb tucked.
Uraken uchi	back-fist strike	Snap from the elbow, retract fast.
Kentsui (tettsui) uchi	hammer-fist	Bottom of fist; heavy and relaxed.
Shotei (teisho) uchi	palm-heel strike	Fingers back, hit with the heel of the palm.
Haito uchi	ridge-hand	Thumb side of the hand, thumb tucked under.
Hiji ate	elbow strike	Short and close; Shito-ryu drills *hiji ate goho* (five elbow directions).

Uke (blocks)

Name	Meaning	One-line cue
Gedan barai	downward sweep	Start at opposite ear, sweep past the knee, finish a fist above the thigh.

Age uke	rising block	Forearm angled above the forehead; deflect up and out.
Yoko uke / soto uke	outside middle block	From outside toward center; elbow a fist-width from the body.
Uchi uke / yoko uchi uke	inside middle block	From inside outward across the body; rotate the wrist at the end.
Shuto uke	knife-hand block	Usually in neko-ashi or kokutsu; rear hand guards the solar plexus.
Nagashi uke	flowing/parry block	Redirect, don't collide (ryusui).
Osae uke	pressing block	Palm presses the attack down.
Sukui uke	scooping block	Scoop a kicking leg upward.
Kakiwake uke	wedge block	Arms spread outward to break a two-hand grab.
Juji / kosa uke	X-block	Wrists crossed, push through the line of attack.
Kake uke (kakete)	hooking block	Hook and control the wrist, ready to grab.
Shotei uke	palm-heel block	Palm heel deflects (Naha-te flavor).
Morote uke	augmented block	Second hand supports the blocking arm.

Geri (kicks)

Name	Meaning	One-line cue
Mae geri	front kick	Knee up first, snap with the ball of the foot, retract before landing.
Mae-ashi geri	front-leg kick	Kick off the front leg without telegraphing.
Mawashi geri	roundhouse kick	Pivot the support foot, knee points at target; instep or ball.
Yoko geri (sokuto)	side kick	Chamber high, thrust with foot edge/heel, hip turns over.

Ushiro geri	back kick	Look over the shoulder, drive the heel straight back.
Ura mawashi / ushiro mawashi geri	hook / spinning hook kick	Hook with heel or sole; keep guard and balance.
Fumikomi geri	stomping kick	Drive the heel down to knee or foot.
Hiza geri	knee strike	Pull the target in, drive the knee up.
Tobi geri	jumping kicks	Listed in some dan syllabi; land balanced.

Typical shodan combination drills (example from a published syllabus)

- Moto-dachi chudan kamae: *mae geri* → *yoko geri* → *mawashi geri* on one leg without putting it down.
- Zenkutsu dachi forward, back and diagonally back: *gedan barai + gyaku-zuki, yoko uke + gyaku-zuki, uchi uke + gyaku-zuki, age uke + gyaku-zuki*.
- Neko-ashi chudan yoko uke → front-leg *mae geri* → *jodan mawashi geri* → land in moto-dachi with *gyaku-zuki* → shift back and repeat.

Source: Shitoryu Karate Canada student manual (shodan). Katsu Dojo's combinations may differ.

Uke no go gensoku: Mabuni's five principles of defence

Principle	Meaning	Idea / example
Rakka	falling petals	A block strong enough to destroy the attack (gedan barai, soto uke).
Ryusui	flowing water	Flow around the attack (nagashi uke, osae uke).
Kusshin	elasticity	Sink or recoil, then spring back (zenkutsu → kokutsu, moto-dachi → neko-ashi).
Ten'i	shifting position	Move off the line in any of eight directions.
Hangeki	counter-attack	Defend and strike as one (tsuki-uke, yama-zuki, morote-zuki).

3 · Kata typically required up to shodan

Typical, not definitive. Movement counts are **approximate**: schools count differently and Shito-ryu versions differ from Shotokan versions of the same name. **Pinan order:** in Shito-ryu, *Pinan Nidan* is usually learned first and matches Shotokan's *Heian Shodan* (Pinan Shodan ≈ Heian Nidan). Lineage tags: Itosu-kei Shuri-te · Higaonna-kei Naha-te · Tomari-te (grouped with Itosu-kei in many lists) · Shito-ryu created . Tap a card to open it.

Pinan Nidan

Itosu-kei · Tokui option · ~21 moves

≈ Heian Shodan (Shotokan)

ORIGIN

Created by Anko Itosu in the early 1900s for schoolchildren; in Shito-ryu usually the first Pinan taught.

KEY POINTS

- H-shaped embusen; start and finish on the same spot
- Gedan barai → oi-zuki pattern with strong turns; look before turning
- Age-uke series up the center line, kiai on the last
- Shuto-uke on the final diagonals

COMMON MISTAKES

- Short, high stances on the turns
- Hikite not pulled to the hip
- Finishing off the starting point
- Rushing, no pause between combinations

Pinan Shodan

Itosu-kei | Tokui option | ~26 moves

≈ Heian Nidan (Shotokan)

ORIGIN

Itosu-kei; the second Pinan in Shito-ryu order.

KEY POINTS

- Opening double-arm block to the side
- Yoko geri + uraken to both sides
- Nukite and shuto sequences
- Clear kiai points

COMMON MISTAKES

- Kick chambered low or not retracted
- Arms not finishing together
- Losing balance on side kicks

Pinan Sandan

Itosu-kei | Tokui option | ~20 moves

≈ Heian Sandan

ORIGIN

Itosu-kei.

KEY POINTS

- Close-range simultaneous blocks
- Stomping section with elbow and back-fist
- Final rear strikes driven by the hips

COMMON MISTAKES

- Weak hip rotation on simultaneous blocks
- Stance too narrow on the stomping section

Pinan Yondan

Itosu-kei | Tokui option | ~27 moves

≈ Heian Yondan

ORIGIN

Itosu-kei.

KEY POINTS

- Slow opening moves: control and breath
- Yoko geri + hiji ate into the open hand
- Hiza geri (knee) with a pull-down
- Kakiwake uke + mae geri + double punch

COMMON MISTAKES

- Slow moves turn sloppy instead of controlled
- Elbow misses the target hand
- Wobbling before the kick

Pinan Godan

Itosu-kei | Tokui option | ~23 moves

≈ Heian Godan

ORIGIN

Itosu-kei; the most advanced Pinan.

KEY POINTS

- Juji uke (X-block) low and high
- The jump (or turning step) with kiai
- Kosa-dachi landing
- Manji-type defence near the end

COMMON MISTAKES

- Heavy or off-balance landing after the jump
- X-block with bent wrists
- No chakugan before turns

Naihanchin Shodan

Itosu-kei | Tokui option | ~25–30 moves

Naifanchi; ≈ Tekki Shodan

ORIGIN

Shuri-te kata emphasised by Itosu; sideways embusen in naihanchi-dachi.

KEY POINTS

- Low, rooted straddle stance throughout
- Crossing steps sideways (kosa-ashi)
- Nami-gaeshi (returning-wave) foot
- Hip snap on every close-range technique

COMMON MISTAKES

- Stance rising during crossing steps
- Knees collapsing inward
- Leaning toward the direction of travel

Bassai Dai

Itosu-kei | Commonly mandatory | ~40–42 moves

Passai: "to penetrate/storm a fortress"

ORIGIN

Shuri-te, Itosu-kei. One of Shito-ryu's two designated (shitei) kata; listed as mandatory at shodan by several Shito-ryu federations.

KEY POINTS

- Explosive opening drive forward
- Alternating uchi/soto uke with full hip reversal
- Shuto-uke in neko-ashi, then sukui uke (scoop)
- Two-hand techniques and strong kiai
- Rhythm: bursts of speed with deliberate pauses

COMMON MISTAKES

- Hips don't change direction on alternating blocks
- Opening drive weak or off-line
- Neko-ashi too long, weight forward
- Pauses blurred so the kata looks rushed

Seienchin

Higaonna-kei | Commonly mandatory | ~35–40 (counts vary widely) moves

Often "calm/lull in the storm" (translations vary)

ORIGIN

Naha-te, Higaonna-kei; one of Shito-ryu's two designated (shitei) kata. Contains no kicks.

KEY POINTS

- Long slow sections in deep shiko-dachi with tension and breathing
- Contrast: heavy slow moves erupting into fast strikes
- Sanchin-dachi and neko-ashi segments
- Close-range pulls, elbows and hammer-fists

COMMON MISTAKES

- Shiko-dachi rises or knees cave as legs tire
- Slow parts lose tension
- Noisy, forced breathing
- Fast parts lack snap, so there's no contrast

Jion

Tomari-te | Tokui / often nidan | ~47 moves

Named after a temple

ORIGIN

Tomari/Shuri lineage, grouped with Itosu-kei. Optional at shodan in some syllabi; mandatory at nidan in others (e.g., Karate Canada).

KEY POINTS

- Jiai-no-kamae opening (left palm over right fist)
- Strong zenkutsu and shiko-dachi work
- Kakiwake uke and manji uke
- Powerful, deliberate rhythm

COMMON MISTAKES

- Careless opening salute
- Manji uke arms unclear
- Bobbing up and down between stances

Matsukaze

Tomari-te | Tokui / sometimes nidan | short (~25–30) moves

"Wind in the pines" (originally Wankan)

ORIGIN

Tomari-te kata (Matsumora lineage) known as Wankan, called Matsukaze in Shito-ryu; the renaming is usually credited to Kenwa Mabuni, though some historians dispute this. Not the same as Shotokan's Wankan. Mandatory at nidan in Shitoryu Karate Canada; a shodan choice in other groups.

KEY POINTS

- Attack and defence in one motion
- Rapid side-to-side punch sequences
- Kicks with changing legs
- Continuous forward pressure

COMMON MISTAKES

- Side-to-side punches break the stance
- Leg-change kicks off balance
- Rushing so techniques run together

Jitte

Tomari-te | Tokui option | ~24 moves

"Ten hands"

ORIGIN

Tomari-te, grouped with Itosu-kei.

KEY POINTS

- Palm-heel (teisho) techniques
- Staff-defence movements
- Strong shiko-dachi

COMMON MISTAKES

- Palm strikes with loose wrists
- Stance too high

Juroku

Shito-ryu created | Tokui option | 16 moves

"Sixteen"

ORIGIN

Created within Shito-ryu in the 20th century (attributed to the Mabuni family; sources differ).

KEY POINTS

- Short and crisp: every move must be sharp
- Clear kiai

COMMON MISTAKES

- Treating it casually because it's short

Shinsei

Shito-ryu created | Tokui option | short moves

ORIGIN

Shito-ryu teaching kata with Naha-te (Higaonna) character.

KEY POINTS

- Sanchin-dachi and Naha-te breathing
- Circular blocks

COMMON MISTAKES

- Rigid shoulders
- Breathing not coordinated with technique

Rohai (Itosu Rohai Shodan / Matsumura Rohai)

Itosu-kei | Tokui option | short moves

"Vision of a heron"

ORIGIN

Itosu's Rohai series and the older Matsumura/Matsumora Rohai.

KEY POINTS

- One-leg (sagi-ashi) balance
- Precise direction changes

COMMON MISTAKES

- Wobbling in the one-leg stance

4 · Bunkai prompts

Bunkai ("analysis") means demonstrating what kata movements do against a partner. Be ready to show at least the required kata (often Bassai Dai) and your tokui kata. Work these prompts with a partner at realistic distance and speed.

General prompts

- What is the attack, and from which direction of the embusen?
- What does the **hikite** do: grab, pull, trap?
- Why this stance here: closing in, moving off-line, dropping weight?
- Which of the five uke principles is shown?
- What's the finish: strike, throw, lock or escape?
- Can you show a second layer, like a "block" used as a strike or a grab release?

Kata-specific prompts

- **Pinan Nidan**: first gedan barai + tettsui against a punch; each turn = a threat from a new direction.
- **Pinan Shodan/Godan**: the shuto sequence; juji uke against a front kick; age-uke with hikite pulling the attacker in.
- **Bassai Dai**: the opening drive as closing distance; switching uchi/soto uke with hip reversal; sukui uke against a kick; two-hand movements as locks or throws.
- **Seienchin**: escapes from wrist grabs in the slow shiko-dachi sections; low pulls as off-balancing; close elbows and hammer-fists.
- **Jion**: kakiwake uke against a two-hand grab or push; manji uke against attacks from two sides.
- **Matsukaze**: side-to-side punches and leg-switching kicks as continuous pressure.
- **Naihanchin**: fighting with your back to a wall; nami-gaeshi as a kick check.

Presentation tips: bow to your partner, say what you're showing ("Bassai Dai, opening sequence"), demonstrate slowly once, then at speed with control, and finish with zanshin. Agree on the attacks with your partner beforehand. Simple and convincing beats flashy.

5 · Kumite (sparring)

Ippon kumite

One-step prearranged. The attacker announces the target and steps in with one technique (e.g., jodan oi-zuki); the defender blocks and counters once with kime, then zanshin. Graders watch distance, timing, a decisive counter and eye contact.

Sanbon kumite

Three-step. The attacker advances with three attacks; the defender retreats with three blocks and counters on the last. Keep stances deep and lines straight; the final counter must be sharp.

Jiyu ippon / jiyu kumite

Jiyu ippon: free movement with one announced attack. *Jiyu kumite*: free sparring, which most Shito-ryu federations expect at shodan. Some syllabi also include *hokei kumite* (prearranged Pinan applications).

Tuesday sparring tips

- **Treat Tuesdays as a test rehearsal.** Ask a senior to call hajime/yame and watch one thing you're fixing.
- **Control first.** Examiners penalise excessive contact far more than missed points. Skin-touch to jodan, controlled to chudan.
- **Own the distance (maai).** Bounce in moto-dachi just out of range; enter as they move.
- **Three go-to combos:** kizami-zuki → gyaku-zuki; mae-ashi geri → gyaku-zuki; jodan feint → chudan mawashi geri.
- **One counter you own:** drill a single block-counter (e.g., nagashi uke + gyaku-zuki) until it's automatic.
- **Finish every exchange** with your guard up and zanshin. Don't turn away or drop your hands.
- **Conditioning:** spar 3–4 × 2-minute rounds so you aren't gassed on test day.
- **Gear & safety:** mouthguard and the mitts/foot protection your dojo requires; hydrate in the Gainesville heat.
- **Etiquette:** bow in and out, acknowledge good techniques, accept the referee's call.

Know the calls: *hajime* (begin), *yame* (stop), *tsuzukete* (continue), *aka/ao* (red/blue). WKF scoring: *yuko* 1 pt, *waza-ari* 2 pts, *ippon* 3 pts.

6 · Kobudo (weapons) note

Katsu Dojo offers Okinawan kobudo: **bo** (6-ft staff), **tonfa**, **sai**, **kama**, **nunchaku** and **tanbo** (short stick). Daniel trains weapons **after Wednesday class**. Many karate shodan tests do **not** require kobudo, but some dojos ask for a basic weapon kata or demonstration, so **ask Sensei** whether it's on the test.

- Bow to the weapon before and after use; never step over a weapon; carry it under control.
- Weapon work should show the same empty-hand fundamentals: stances, hips, kime.
- Know the names of your weapon kata and a line of history if asked. Common Okinawan examples include *Shushi no Kon* (bo) and *Tsuken Shitahaku no Sai* (sai); Katsu Dojo's own list may differ.
- Use Wednesdays to rehearse one weapon form calmly. It's good grip and forearm conditioning too.

7 · Terminology, counting, etiquette & dojo kun

Counting 1–10

#	Romaji	#	Romaji
1	*ichi*	6	*roku*
2	*ni*	7	*shichi (nana)*
3	*san*	8	*hachi*
4	*shi (yon)*	9	*ku (kyu)*
5	*go*	10	*ju*

Glossary

Term	Meaning	Group
Rei	bow / courtesy	Etiquette
Seiza	formal kneeling	Etiquette
Mokuso	meditation (eyes closed)	Etiquette
Shomen ni rei	bow to the front	Etiquette
Sensei ni rei	bow to the teacher	Etiquette
Otagai ni rei	bow to each other	Etiquette
Osu	acknowledgement (dojo-dependent)	Etiquette
Sempai / Kohai	senior / junior student	Etiquette
Dojo	"place of the way" (training hall)	Etiquette
Dojo kun	dojo precepts	Etiquette
Gi / Obi	uniform / belt	Etiquette
Yoi	get ready	Commands

Hajime	begin	Commands
Yame	stop	Commands
Naore	return to position	Commands
Mawatte	turn around	Commands
Kiritsu	stand up	Commands
Tsuzukete	continue	Commands
Kiai	spirit shout	Commands
Karate-do	way of the empty hand	Concepts
Kihon	basics	Concepts
Kata	form / pattern	Concepts
Kumite	sparring ("meeting of hands")	Concepts
Bunkai	analysis / application of kata	Concepts
Kime	focus of power at impact	Concepts
Zanshin	remaining alert after a technique	Concepts
Maai	fighting distance	Concepts
Chakugan	where the eyes look (look before turning)	Concepts
Embusen	performance line of a kata	Concepts
Hikite	pulling-back hand	Concepts
Kamae	guard / ready posture	Concepts
Tai sabaki	body shifting / evasion	Concepts
Shitei kata	designated / required kata	Concepts
Tokui kata	favorite / chosen kata	Concepts
Kyu / Dan	grade below black belt / black-belt degree	Concepts
Shodan	1st-degree black belt ("beginning degree")	Concepts

Uke / Tori	defender / executor	Concepts
Jodan	upper level (head)	Levels & sides
Chudan	middle level (torso)	Levels & sides
Gedan	lower level	Levels & sides
Migi / Hidari	right / left	Levels & sides
Mae / Ushiro / Yoko	front / back / side	Levels & sides
Dachi (tachi)	stance	Techniques
Tsuki (zuki)	punch / thrust	Techniques
Uchi	strike	Techniques
Uke	block / receive	Techniques
Geri (keri)	kick	Techniques
Gyaku-zuki	reverse punch	Techniques
Oi-zuki	lunge punch	Techniques
Gedan barai	downward sweeping block	Techniques
Age uke	rising block	Techniques
Shuto	knife hand	Techniques
Mawashi geri	roundhouse kick	Techniques
Neko ashi dachi	cat stance	Techniques
Shiko dachi	square (sumo) stance	Techniques
Zenkutsu dachi	front stance	Techniques
Moto dachi	short front (fighting) stance	Techniques
Rakka	falling petals: block that destroys the attack	Uke principles
Ryusui	flowing water: deflect	Uke principles
Kusshin	elasticity: sink and spring back	Uke principles

Ten'i	shifting position off the line	Uke principles
Hangeki	counter-attack while defending	Uke principles

Dojo etiquette (reigi)

- Bow (*ritsurei*) when entering or leaving the dojo and stepping on or off the mat.
- Be on time. If you're late, kneel at the edge and wait for Sensei's permission to join.
- Clean gi, trimmed nails, no jewelry, belt tied properly.
- Line up by rank following your dojo's custom.
- Answer instructions with "*Osu*" or "Hai, Sensei," whichever your dojo uses.
- Bow to partners before and after drills. Never leave the mat without permission.
- Turn away from the front to fix your gi or belt.
- Respect weapons and equipment; help clean the dojo.

Dojo kun (common version)

Many karate dojos, including many Shito-ryu ones, recite a five-line dojo kun. Wording varies. A widely used form:

1. *Hitotsu, jinkaku kansei ni tsutomuru koto*: Seek perfection of character.
2. *Hitotsu, makoto no michi o mamoru koto*: Be faithful; follow the way of truth.
3. *Hitotsu, doryoku no seishin o yashinau koto*: Cultivate a spirit of effort.
4. *Hitotsu, reigi o omonzuru koto*: Respect others; value etiquette.
5. *Hitotsu, kekki no yu o imashimuru koto*: Refrain from violent behavior.

Confirm Katsu Dojo's own dojo kun (if it has one) and memorise that version.

8 · History of Shito-ryu

- **Founder: Kenwa Mabuni** (摩文仁賢和), born in Shuri, Okinawa, 14 Nov 1889; died 23 May 1952. (Most sources; one federation site says 1893.)
- **Teacher 1: Anko Itosu** (糸洲安恒, c. 1831–1915), Shuri-te. Mabuni began training with him around age 13. Itosu brought karate into Okinawan schools in the early 1900s and created the **Pinan** kata. Itosu-kei kata: Pinan, Naihanchin, Bassai, Kosokun, Jion, Jitte, Rohai, Chinto…
- **Teacher 2: Kanryo Higaonna** (東恩納寛量, 1853–1915), Naha-te. Mabuni began with him around age 20 (c. 1909), introduced by his friend **Chojun Miyagi**, later the founder of Goju-ryu. Higaonna-kei kata: Sanchin, Seienchin, Seipai, Kururunfa, Suparinpei…
- **Other influences:** Mabuni also learned from other Okinawan teachers (e.g., Seisho Aragaki) and absorbed Chinese White Crane forms (e.g., Nipaipo, Papuren). That's why Shito-ryu has one of the largest kata syllabi, often quoted at 50+ kata.
- **To mainland Japan:** he moved to **Osaka around 1929** (some sources say 1928). His early name for the art was **Hanko-ryu** ("half-hard style"); the WSKF history says he first taught under the name Goju-ryu.
- **The name:** in the 1930s the **Dai Nippon Butoku Kai** pushed styles to register names. Mabuni chose **Shito** (糸東) from the first kanji of **Ito**su (糸, also read "shi") and **Higa**onna (東, also read "to"). It honours both teachers rather than having a literal meaning. *Ryu* = school or style.
- **Dates you may hear:** c. 1931 (Dai Nippon Karatedo Kai study group in Kansai); **1934** (name "Shito-ryu" adopted per WSKF, and the **Yoshukan** dojo opened in Osaka); **1939** (formally registered with the Butoku Kai, Mabuni awarded Renshi). Katsu Dojo's website says "founded by Kenwa Mabuni in 1928." **Safe answer:** "Founded by Kenwa Mabuni in Osaka in the late 1920s–1930s; named Shito-ryu in the 1930s and registered in 1939." If Sensei teaches a specific date, use that.
- **Characteristics:** blends Shuri-te's linear power and long stances with Naha-te's circular, close-range, hard-soft and breathing methods; Mabuni's *uke no go gensoku*; strong emphasis on bunkai.
- **After Mabuni:** his sons **Kenei Mabuni** and **Kenzo Mabuni** carried on the style. Major branches include Shito-kai (Manzo Iwata; today's JKF Shito-kai/WSKF), Hayashi-ha (Teruo Hayashi), Tani-ha/Shukokai (Chojiro Tani) and Itosu-kai (Ryusho Sakagami).
- **Today:** Shito-ryu is one of the four major JKF/WKF styles, with Goju-ryu, Shotokan and Wado-ryu. Bassai Dai and Seienchin are its standard designated (shitei) kata.

9 · 6-week practice plan & self-check

Assumes regular dojo classes plus ~30–45 min of home practice 4–5 days a week. Tuesdays = sparring; Wednesdays = class + weapons. Ticks are saved on this device.

Week 1: Baseline

0/6

- [ ] Get the official test requirements from Sensei (kata, kumite, kobudo, oral)
- [ ] Video yourself doing Pinan 1–5; list 3 fixes per kata
- [ ] Stance drills 20 min: zenkutsu, shiko, neko-ashi; hold 30 s each, check knees
- [ ] Learn counting 1–10 and 20 glossary terms (flashcards)
- [ ] Tuesday: spar 3 × 2 min, focus on control and guard
- [ ] Wednesday weapons: ask whether kobudo is on the test; rehearse your current weapon form

Week 2: Required kata

0/6

- [ ] Bassai Dai × 5 daily (2 slow, 3 at test speed)
- [ ] Seienchin × 3 daily, full-depth shiko-dachi in the slow sections
- [ ] Read the History section; answer oral questions 1–6 out loud
- [ ] Kihon combo: mae–yoko–mawashi on one leg, 10 each side
- [ ] Tuesday: drill ippon and sanbon kumite counters with a partner
- [ ] Quiz: score 80%+ on Terminology

Week 3: Bunkai & tokui

0/6

- [ ] Choose your tokui kata with Sensei; practice it × 5 daily
- [ ] Build Bassai Dai bunkai (3–4 sequences) with a partner
- [ ] Build tokui-kata bunkai (2–3 sequences)
- [ ] Ido kihon up and down the floor with kiai, on count and without
- [ ] Tuesday: jiyu kumite, working your 3 go-to combos
- [ ] Wednesday weapons: one clean, recorded run-through

Week 4: Polish details

0/6

- [ ] Video Bassai Dai, Seienchin and tokui; compare with Sensei or a senior; fix embusen and chakugan
- [ ] Breathing: Seienchin slow sections with controlled breath
- [ ] Practice hiji ate goho and demonstrating the five defence principles
- [ ] Answer all 17 oral questions out loud without notes
- [ ] Tuesday: spar while tired (after conditioning) and keep control
- [ ] Quiz: 80%+ on Kata facts and History

Week 5: Mock test

0/6

- [ ] Full mock test in order: kihon → kata → bunkai → kumite → oral (ask a senior or parent to grade)
- [ ] All Pinan in random order, called by someone else
- [ ] Conditioning: 3 × 2-min sparring rounds + 50 shiko-dachi squats
- [ ] Fix the 3 weakest points from the mock
- [ ] Tuesday: sparring rounds with multiple partners
- [ ] Quiz: 90%+ on All topics

Week 6: Taper & test 0/6

- [ ] Light practice: each required kata × 3 crisp runs, no new material
- [ ] Final bunkai run-through with your test partner
- [ ] Review the glossary and dojo kun once a day
- [ ] Pack gi, belt, mouthguard, gear and water the night before
- [ ] Sleep well; eat light before the test
- [ ] Test day: bow, breathe, kiai, zanshin. You're ready.

Self-check checklist: ready to test?

- [ ] I know every kata on my dojo's list in order, without hesitation
- [ ] My start and finish points match in every kata (embusen)
- [ ] My stances hold depth through Seienchin's slow sections
- [ ] Every technique has a clear hikite and kime
- [ ] I look before every turn (chakugan)
- [ ] My kiai points are correct and strong
- [ ] I can show 3+ bunkai for Bassai Dai and my tokui kata
- [ ] My ippon and sanbon kumite counters are sharp and controlled
- [ ] I can spar 2 minutes of jiyu kumite without losing control or guard
- [ ] I can name stances, blocks, strikes and kicks in Japanese
- [ ] I can count 1–10 and explain kime, zanshin, maai and bunkai
- [ ] I can explain who founded Shito-ryu and what the name means
- [ ] I can name the five defence principles
- [ ] I know Katsu Dojo's dojo kun and etiquette
- [ ] I know whether kobudo is on my test (and can perform it if so)

10 · Likely oral questions, with answers

Tap a question to reveal the answer. Answer in your own words: short, confident, respectful.

▼ 1. Who founded Shito-ryu, and where?

Kenwa Mabuni (1889–1952), from Shuri, Okinawa. He developed and taught the style in Osaka, Japan, after moving there around 1929.

▼ 2. What does "Shito" mean?

It combines the first kanji of his two main teachers' names: Itosu (糸, read "shi") and Higaonna (東, read "to"). It honours them rather than having a literal meaning. "Ryu" means school or style.

▼ 3. Who were Mabuni's two main teachers, and what did each teach?

Anko Itosu taught Shuri-te: linear, powerful techniques and long stances (Pinan, Naihanchin, Bassai). Kanryo Higaonna taught Naha-te: circular, close-range, hard-soft techniques with breathing (Sanchin, Seienchin).

▼ 4. When was Shito-ryu founded?

It was developed in the late 1920s–1930s. The name Shito-ryu was adopted in the 1930s (around 1934, when the Yoshukan dojo opened in Osaka) and formally registered with the Dai Nippon Butoku Kai in 1939. (Katsu Dojo's site says 1928; use Sensei's date if he gives one.)

▼ 5. What was the style's earlier name?

Hanko-ryu, meaning "half-hard style."

▼ 6. What are the five principles of defence (uke no go gensoku)?

Rakka (falling petals: destroy the attack), Ryusui (flowing water: deflect), Kusshin (elasticity: sink and spring back), Ten'i (shift off the line), Hangeki (counter-attack while defending).

▼ 7. Which kata come from the Itosu lineage and which from the Higaonna lineage?

Itosu-kei: Pinan 1–5, Naihanchin, Bassai Dai, Jion, Jitte, Rohai, Kosokun. Higaonna-kei: Sanchin, Seienchin, Seipai, Kururunfa, Suparinpei, Shisochin.

▼ 8. Who created the Pinan kata, and why?

Anko Itosu, in the early 1900s, as simpler kata for teaching karate to Okinawan schoolchildren.

▼ 9. What do kime and zanshin mean?

Kime is total focus of power at the moment of impact. Zanshin is staying aware and ready after a technique.

▼ 10. What is bunkai, and why does it matter?

It's the analysis and application of kata movements. It shows you understand the kata as real technique, not just a pattern.

▼ 11. What does shodan mean to you?

Literally "beginning degree." It's the start of serious study, not the end: a responsibility to keep learning, set an example and help juniors. (Put this in your own words.)

▼ 12. What do Seienchin and Bassai mean?

Seienchin is often translated "calm in the storm" (translations vary). Bassai means "to penetrate" or "storm a fortress."

▼ 13. What is Matsukaze's original name?

Wankan, a Tomari-te kata. Shito-ryu calls it Matsukaze, "wind in the pines."

▼ 14. Why do we bow?

To show respect and gratitude to the dojo, teachers and partners. It also marks the mental switch into training.

▼ 15. Recite the dojo kun.

Use your dojo's version. A common one: seek perfection of character; be faithful; cultivate effort; respect others; refrain from violent behavior.

▼ 16. What makes Shito-ryu different from other styles?

It unites Shuri-te and Naha-te, has a very large kata syllabus (50+), and emphasises bunkai and the five principles of defence. It's fast, powerful and technical.

▼ 17. Name the four major JKF/WKF styles.

Shito-ryu, Goju-ryu, Shotokan and Wado-ryu.

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